

What Elders Are For

A Biblical Job Description for the Men Who Lead the Church

JAMES BELL

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Contents

WHAT ELDERS ARE FOR	1
WHAT ELDERS ARE FOR	
Contents	3
Contents	
Foreword: A Word to the Pastor	4
Reading This	
Foreword: A Word to the Pastor Reading This	
Introduction: The Problem This Book	6
Was Written to Solve	
Introduction: The Problem This Book Was Written to Solve	
Boards That Govern Instead of	10
Shepherd	
Boards That Govern Instead of Shepherd	
The Elder as Shepherd	16
The Elder as Shepherd	
The Elder as Teacher	24
The Elder as Teacher	
The Elder as Overseer	30
The Elder as Overseer	

The Elder’s Personal Life as Ministry	36
The Elder’s Personal Life as Ministry	
Building an Elder Team That Functions Biblically	42
Building an Elder Team That Functions Biblically	
Conclusion: A Reset	50
Conclusion: A Reset	
Appendix	54
Appendix	

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Pastors Connection Network

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WHAT ELDERS ARE FOR

Contents

FOREWORD—A WORD TO THE Pastor Reading This

Introduction—The Problem This Book Was Written to Solve

Chapter 1—Boards That Govern Instead of Shepherd

Chapter 2—The Elder as Shepherd: Back to the Bible

Chapter 3 The Elder as Teacher: Guarding and Proclaiming Truth

Chapter 4 The Elder as Overseer: Leading Without Micromanaging

Chapter 5—The Elder's Personal Life as Ministry

Chapter 6 Building an Elder Team That Functions Biblically

Conclusion A Reset: Toward Elders Who Actually Shepherd

Appendix A Sample Elder Role Description and Team Covenant

Foreword: A Word to the Pastor Reading This

YOU PROBABLY DIDN'T PICK up this book because things are going well with your elder team.

Maybe you're sitting in month six of a pastorate wondering why the men who are supposed to be your partners spend every meeting arguing about the parking lot. Maybe you've been in ministry long enough to recognize the pattern — you arrive at a church, you try to lead, and sooner or later you encounter a wall of informal power that has no theological justification but enormous practical force. Or maybe you're a newer pastor, full of vision, and you've just had your first elder meeting and walked out feeling more alone than when you walked in.

Whatever brought you here, you are not alone.

Elder dysfunction is one of the most common, most damaging, and least discussed problems in the local church. Books on church governance treat it as an organizational problem. Books on leadership treat it as a management

That is what this book is about.

It is not a comprehensive treatment of elder theology. It is a field guide for the pastor who is living with the gap between what elders should be and what they often are. It is also a hopeful book, because most elder teams are not beyond redemption. Most deacon boards, most trustee committees, most church boards have men in them who genuinely love God and genuinely love the church. They just don't know what they're supposed to be doing.

That is something that can be changed.

Read this book with your elders. Better yet, read it before you take a new call and use it to set expectations from day one. Read it if you're a denominational leader watching churches struggle under dysfunctional governance. Read it if you're a layman who has just been nominated for an elder position and you want to know what you're agreeing to.

Most of all, read it if you are a pastor who is tired of fighting about the wrong things when there are sheep that need to be shepherded.

This book is for you.

Introduction: The Problem This Book Was Written to Solve

THERE IS A MAN in almost every established church in America who has been an elder or deacon for longer than the current pastor has been alive. He is not a bad man. He loves his church. He has given decades of faithful, sacrificial service. He has chaired committees, painted the fellowship hall, called the plumber, and sat with families through every grief the congregation has experienced in his tenure.

And he has absolutely no idea what an elder is supposed to do.

Neither, if we are honest, do most of the men sitting around him.

This is not an accusation. It is an observation about what happens when a church trains its leaders by modeling rather than by Scripture — when the new elder learns his role by

The result is predictable. Elder boards across America have been quietly shaped not by the New Testament's vision of what they should be, but by the culture's vision of what a governing board looks like. They function like a board of directors. They approve budgets and vote on facilities decisions and weigh in on whether the chairs in the fellowship hall should be replaced. They feel authorized to limit the pastor's authority in ministry matters while feeling no particular responsibility to provide pastoral care to the congregation.

They govern when they should be shepherding.

That is the problem this book is written to solve. Not elder conflict, though it will touch on that. Not governance structure, though it will address it. The problem is simpler and more fundamental: most elders don't know what they're for. And the pastors who could tell them are often too conflict-averse, too exhausted, or too unsure themselves to have the conversation.

The New Testament is not ambiguous on this subject. When you read Acts 20, 1 Peter 5, 1 Timothy 3, Titus 1, and Hebrews 13 together, a clear and consistent picture emerges. Elders are shepherds. They are teachers. They are overseers. They are guardians. They are examples. They are men whose whole lives — not just their board service — are an expression of their office.

That picture is almost unrecognizable in most church governance structures today.

Pay careful attention to yourselves and to all the flock, in which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers, to care for the church of God, which he obtained with his own blood. — Acts 20:28

Notice the structure of Paul's charge in Acts 20. The elders of the Ephesian church are called to two things: care for themselves and care for the flock. The self-care comes first — not because it is more important, but because it is foundational. A shepherd who neglects his own soul cannot long shepherd others. But the outward call is unmistakable: the Holy Spirit has made them overseers, and the church they are overseeing was purchased at the price of the blood of God's own Son.

That is the weight of the office. And it is a weight that no governance checklist can carry.

Here is the roadmap for what follows. Chapter One diagnoses the problem — what happens when church boards govern instead of shepherd, and why it matters so much. Chapters Two through Five build the positive picture: the elder as shepherd, the elder as teacher, the elder as overseer, and the elder as an example in his own personal life. Chapter Six addresses the practical questions of how to build an elder team that actually functions according to this vision. The conclusion offers a reset framework — a practical guide for beginning the work of realigning an elder team around its biblical mandate.

This is not easy work. Institutional change rarely is. But it

INTRODUCTION: THE PROBLEM THIS BOOK WAS
WRITTEN TO SOLVE

Let's begin.

CHAPTER ONE

Boards That Govern Instead of Shepherd

HOW WE GOT HERE, what it costs, and why it matters

It would be unfair to blame the deacons.

Or the trustees. Or the elders. Or whatever we are calling the group of laymen who exercise authority in the local church in your context. They did not design the system. They inherited it. Most of them were never told anything different, and many of them are doing exactly what the man before them did, who was doing exactly what the man before him did, in a tradition of institutional modeling so continuous that no one has thought to question it in a very long time.

But the system is broken. And understanding how it broke is the first step toward fixing it.

THE AMERICAN CHURCH BOARD: A BRIEF HISTORY

THE GOVERNANCE STRUCTURES THAT dominate most American evangelical churches today did not develop

In the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, as American churches grew larger and more institutionally complex, church leaders looked to the most successful organizational model available to them: the American corporation. Churches began adopting the language and structure of business — boards of directors, trustees, voting structures, fiduciary responsibility, and the division of authority between an executive (the pastor) and a governing body (the board). This was not done maliciously. It was done pragmatically. The tools of corporate governance seemed to work, and so they were applied to the church.

The problem is that the church is not a corporation. It is the body of Christ. It is a family. It is a household. And when you apply corporate governance structures to a household, you get something that is efficient on paper and dysfunctional in practice.

What you get, specifically, is a group of men whose primary identity in their church role is as decision-makers rather than as shepherds. Men who feel authorized to vote on institutional matters but who have never been told that their calling includes sitting with a grieving widow, or visiting a member in the hospital, or confronting a brother in sin, or praying regularly by name for the people in their congregation.

The result is a kind of structural amnesia — a leadership structure that has forgotten what it was designed to do.

WHAT GOVERNING INSTEAD OF

IT IS WORTH BEING specific about what this dysfunction looks like in practice, because it takes many forms, and not all of them are obvious.

In its most visible form, it looks like the elder board that spends the majority of its meetings on institutional business — budgets, facilities, personnel matters, policies — while the pastoral care of the congregation is left entirely to the paid pastor. The elders are not shepherds in these churches. They are governors. And when the congregation needs care that exceeds the pastor's capacity, there is no one to provide it.

In a more subtle form, it looks like the elder board that uses its authority as a check on pastoral leadership rather than as a support for it. These are the boards where the primary function of the elders is to limit what the pastor can do rather than to extend what the church can do. Every significant ministry decision requires a vote. Every budget line requires approval. Every pastoral initiative faces a structural obstacle course that has nothing to do with theological discernment and everything to do with the exercise of institutional power.

And in its most damaging form, it looks like the individual elder — usually a longtime, highly respected member — who uses his position on the board to protect his preferences, his relationships, or his family's influence in the church. This elder is not corrupt in any obvious sense. He loves his church. But he has confused his love for the church with ownership of it. And he exercises authority in ways that serve his own vision of what the church should be rather than the congregation's actual need for pastoral care.

The cost of all of this is enormous. It shows up in pastor

THE SPIRITUAL DANGER WE MISS

THERE IS SOMETHING DEEPER here than organizational dysfunction, however. Something the language of governance and management tends to obscure.

When church elders fail to shepherd, they are not merely failing in a management role. They are failing in a spiritual calling. And the consequences are not merely organizational — they are pastoral.

Consider what Ezekiel 34 says about shepherds who fail to shepherd. The language is severe: “Woe to the shepherds of Israel who have been feeding themselves! Should not shepherds feed the sheep?” The indictment is specific: the leaders of Israel had been using their position for their own benefit rather than for the care of those entrusted to them. And the consequence was that the sheep were scattered, sick, and lost.

We are tempted to apply this passage only to pastors who are self-serving in obvious ways — those who preach for personal platform, or who extract wealth from their congregations, or who use ministry for self-aggrandizement. But the passage applies with equal force to the elder board

The weak you have not strengthened, the sick you have not healed, the injured you have not bound up, the strayed you have not brought back, the lost you have not sought, and with force and harshness you have ruled them. — Ezekiel 34:4

The application for modern church governance is direct and uncomfortable. When an elder board spends its meetings on facilities and finances while members struggle in isolation, are leaving the faith, or are going unvisited in hospitals and homes — something has gone very wrong. Not only organizationally. Spiritually.

This is why recovering a biblical understanding of eldership is not a matter of preference or polity style. It is a matter of faithfulness to the call God has given to these men.

THE PASTOR WHO BEARS THIS ALONE

WE SHOULD ALSO SAY something about the cost this dysfunction imposes on pastors specifically, because it is significant.

The pastor of a church with a governance-focused elder board is, in most cases, providing the pastoral care for an entire congregation without any meaningful help. He is preaching, counseling, visiting, comforting, confronting, leading, administering, fundraising, and — if the board is the controlling type — also navigating a relentless obstacle course every time he wants to do something.

This is not sustainable. The statistics on pastor burnout, pastor attrition, and pastor mental health all point to the same underlying reality: we have built a church system that

The biblical vision is not one pastor surrounded by a board of governors. It is a team of shepherd-leaders, each contributing his gifts and care to the flock, multiplying the pastoral coverage of the congregation and distributing the weight of leadership across a plurality of qualified men.

When that vision is recovered — when elder boards are rebuilt as elder teams in the genuine sense — the pastor is not diminished. He is freed. Freed to lead, to preach, to disciple, and to rest, knowing that the flock he loves is being cared for by men who take their calling as seriously as he does his.

That is the vision this book is trying to recover. Not in a day, and not without significant pastoral investment. But the journey begins with a clear picture of what elders are actually for. And to that picture we now turn.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What governance structures in your church were inherited rather than designed from Scripture? What would change if you rebuilt them from a biblical starting point?

If you are honest, what percentage of your current elder/board meeting agenda is devoted to institutional governance versus pastoral care and spiritual oversight?

What specific members or ministry areas are going without adequate pastoral care because the responsibility is concentrated in one person?

What is the cost — to you, to the congregation, and to the mission — of the current structure? Have you ever named it out loud?

CHAPTER TWO

The Elder as Shepherd

WHAT THE NEW TESTAMENT actually says about what elders do

Before we can build something better, we need to see it clearly.

The New Testament has a great deal to say about what elders are supposed to do. The problem is not a shortage of biblical material — it is that we have read that material through the lens of our existing governance structures rather than allowing it to challenge and reshape them. When we come to Acts 20 or 1 Peter 5 with a corporate governance model already in mind, we tend to absorb only the parts that fit the model and quietly ignore the parts that don't.

This chapter is an attempt to read the relevant texts on their own terms, and to let them give us a picture of eldership that is genuinely biblical rather than merely institutionally familiar.

**THE LANGUAGE THE NEW TESTAMENT
USES**

revealing things about the New Testament's vision for church leadership is the language it chooses. The three primary words used for the office we translate as "elder" are instructive.

The first is *presbuteros* — elder. This is the most common term, and it emphasizes the dignity, maturity, and wisdom that should characterize those who lead the church. An elder is not merely a person with institutional authority. He is a person of demonstrated character and wisdom whose leadership is an expression of his life rather than just his title.

The second is *episkopos* — overseer or bishop. This word emphasizes the supervisory and protective function of the office. The overseer watches over the flock, guards against threats, and ensures that the community is cared for and ordered well. It is the word Paul uses in Acts 20:28 when he commissions the Ephesian elders: the Holy Spirit has made you overseers.

The third — and most theologically loaded — is *poimen* — shepherd. This is the word used in Ephesians 4:11, where Paul lists the gifts Christ gave to the church, and it is the pastoral metaphor that runs like a thread through every major New Testament text on church leadership. Elders are shepherds. This is not incidental language. It is definitional.

Shepherd the flock of God that is among you, exercising oversight, not under compulsion but willingly, as God would have you; not for shameful gain but eagerly; not domineering over those in your charge, but being examples to the flock. — 1 Peter 5:2–3

The shepherd metaphor is not merely decorative. It carries enormous practical content. In the ancient world, everyone knew what shepherds did. They fed their animals.

Apply that picture to the elder's relationship with the congregation and the contrast with modern church governance becomes stark. A board of directors does not personally know every shareholder. An elder who is a shepherd must know every sheep.

ACTS 20: THE ELDER'S CHARGE

THE MOST COMPREHENSIVE PICTURE of elder responsibility in the New Testament appears in Paul's farewell address to the elders of Ephesus in Acts 20. It is worth examining in detail because it assembles in one passage almost everything the New Testament says about what elders are for.

Paul begins by reminding the elders of his own example among them. He served with humility, with tears, through trials. He declared the whole counsel of God without shrinking. He taught in public and in private. He kept nothing back that was profitable for them. The pastoral model he is presenting is not a professional one — it is a personal, sacrificial, comprehensive one.

Then he turns to the elders themselves. "Pay careful attention to yourselves and to all the flock." The order matters. Self-care precedes flock care, not because the elders are more important than the sheep, but because a shepherd who neglects his own soul will eventually have nothing left to give. The disciplined inner life of the elder is not a private luxury. It is a structural necessity for the health of the whole.

The Threat that Makes Shepherding Urgent

Paul does not stop with the positive commission. He immediately describes the threat that makes shepherding so urgently necessary. Fierce wolves will come in — some from outside, some from among the elders themselves — speaking twisted things and drawing disciples after them.

This is one of the most sobering passages in the New Testament for church leaders. Paul is not describing a theoretical threat. He is describing something he knows will happen. And the only defense against it is elders who are alert, grounded in truth, and relationally close enough to the flock to notice when a wolf has gotten among them.

A governance committee that meets monthly to approve budgets will not catch this. A board of institutional overseers whose primary concern is financial health will not be positioned to notice when a member's theology is drifting, or when a small group has become a forum for theological confusion, or when a charismatic newcomer is beginning to draw a faction within the congregation.

Only shepherds — men who know their sheep well enough to notice when something is wrong — will catch it in time.

1 PETER 5: THE CHARACTER OF ELDER OVERSIGHT

PETER'S INSTRUCTION IN 1 Peter 5 focuses less on the functions of eldership and more on the character that

Shepherd the flock of God that is among you, he says — and then three contrasts follow. Not under compulsion but willingly. Not for shameful gain but eagerly. Not domineering over those in your charge, but being examples.

The compulsion/willingness contrast addresses motivation. The elder who shepherds because he feels obligated — because it is expected of him, because his family has always been part of the leadership, because it would look strange if he declined — is not fulfilling the office in the spirit Peter intends. Shepherding requires genuine desire. It requires men who actually want to care for the flock.

The shameful gain/eagerness contrast addresses orientation. The elder must not be in the position for what it gives him — status, influence, insider access to institutional decisions. He must be in it for what he can give. The eagerness Peter describes is the eagerness of someone who has been given responsibility for something precious and who is genuinely motivated to protect and nurture it.

The domineering/example contrast is perhaps the most revealing. Peter is not prohibiting authority. Elders have genuine authority over the congregation — Hebrews 13 is explicit about this. But the authority of the elder is moral authority, not institutional power. It is the authority that comes from being an example — from living in such a way that the congregation can see what it looks like to follow Christ, and can follow the elder's example as a guide.

Peter closes this section by reminding elders that they are under-shepherds. The Chief Shepherd is Christ. When he

HEBREWS 13: AUTHORITY IN THE SERVICE OF THE CONGREGATION

HEBREWS 13:17 IS ONE of the most important texts for understanding the relationship between elder authority and elder responsibility. “Obey your leaders and submit to them, for they are keeping watch over your souls, as those who will have to give an account.”

Notice the structure. The reason the congregation is called to obey its leaders is not institutional. It is pastoral. The leaders are keeping watch over your souls. They will give account. The authority of the elder is grounded in a specific responsibility — the care of souls — and will be evaluated against that specific responsibility.

This should radically reshape how we think about elder authority. It is not authority over institutional decisions. It is authority in the service of spiritual care. And it comes with a weight of accountability that a purely institutional governance role never carries.

The man who votes on the church budget as a member of a governing board carries a relatively light accountability. He exercised good judgment with institutional resources. But the man who is keeping watch over souls — who is responsible before God for the spiritual welfare of specific people

This weight should both humble every elder and clarify his purpose. He is not a policy-maker. He is a soul-keeper.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE ELDER'S WEEK

IT IS WORTH ASKING what all of this looks like in practice — not in theory or in a carefully structured elder team at a large church, but in the ordinary weekly life of an elder in a small to medium-sized congregation.

If elders are shepherds, their weeks should include the kinds of activities that shepherds engage in. They should be praying regularly and specifically for the members of the congregation assigned to their care. They should be reaching out proactively — a phone call to check in, a coffee to catch up, a text to let someone know they are seen. They should be attending to the spiritual health of the people they oversee, noticing when someone stops attending, following up when a family seems to be struggling, being present in the kinds of ways that make pastoral care feel personal rather than institutional.

They should also be engaged in the life of the church beyond board meetings. They should be attending small groups. They should be known in the congregation as men who are safe to approach with struggles and questions. They should be modeling the Christian life in ways that are visible enough to be examples.

This is not a job description that any governance structure produces on its own. It is a calling that must be cultivated, modeled, and expected.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What would it take for your elder team to genuinely know every member of the congregation well enough to notice when something was wrong?

What does “keeping watch over souls” actually look like in the weekly calendar of your elder team members?

If Peter’s three contrasts (willing, eager, exemplary) were applied to your current elders as an evaluation framework, what would the honest result be?

CHAPTER THREE

The Elder as Teacher

GUARDING THE TRUTH AND training the congregation

There is a qualification for elders that rarely makes it into modern elder selection conversations. Not because it is ambiguous or obscure. It is right there in 1 Timothy 3, in the middle of the list. The elder must be “able to teach.”

Most churches treat this phrase as a kind of asterisk — a minimum threshold that almost any reasonably intelligent man can clear. He doesn’t need to be the main preacher. He just needs to be able to hold his own in a conversation about doctrine. That’s enough, isn’t it?

No. It is not enough. And understanding why — understanding what this qualification actually means and what it requires — is essential to recovering a biblical picture of the teaching ministry of the elder.

WHAT “ABLE TO TEACH” ACTUALLY MEANS

THE GREEK PHRASE IS *didaktikos* — capable of teaching. Paul uses it only twice in the New Testament. Once here in 1 Timothy 3:2, and once in 2 Timothy 2:24,

This is a broader and more demanding qualification than it first appears. It means that an elder must have a sufficiently deep grasp of Scripture and theology that he can articulate truth to those who are confused, answer the questions of those who are seeking, gently correct those who are drifting, and protect the congregation from teaching that is false or misleading.

A man who cannot do this — not from the pulpit necessarily, but in the living room, at the coffee table, in the hospital room — is not ready to be an elder, regardless of his other gifts and his genuine love for the church.

THE DOCTRINAL RESPONSIBILITY OF THE ELDER TEAM

THE TEACHING RESPONSIBILITY OF elders is not limited to the elder who preaches. Every elder carries a responsibility for the doctrinal health of the congregation. This is most clearly stated in Titus 1, where Paul describes elders as men who must “hold firm to the trustworthy word as taught, so that he may be able to give instruction in sound doctrine and also to rebuke those who contradict it” (Titus 1:9).

This is not optional for the elder who prefers administration over theology. This is the job description of

He must hold firm to the trustworthy word as taught, so that he may be able to give instruction in sound doctrine and also to rebuke those who contradict it. — Titus 1:9

Notice the two-sided nature of the responsibility. Give instruction in sound doctrine. Rebuke those who contradict it. The elder's teaching ministry is both constructive and protective. He builds up the congregation through positive theological instruction, and he guards the congregation by addressing teaching that is harmful.

Many elders are comfortable with the first part of this responsibility and deeply uncomfortable with the second. The confrontational dimension of the teaching ministry — the willingness to address false teaching, to name theological error, to say to a popular teacher or trend: "That is not what the Bible says" — requires a kind of courage that institutional governance never demands.

A board member can avoid theological controversy indefinitely. A shepherd cannot.

HOW ELDERS TEACH BEYOND THE PULPIT

THE MOST COMMON PICTURE of elder teaching in evangelical churches is the senior pastor preaching on Sunday morning. And it is true that the preaching ministry is one of the primary ways the congregation receives theological instruction. But if the teaching responsibility of the elder team is confined to the senior pastor's Sunday messages, the congregation is being significantly underserved.

Consider the range of contexts in which ordinary members of a congregation need theological guidance. The

None of these situations will be addressed by a Sunday morning sermon. They require individual attention from someone who knows the person, knows the concern, and is both theologically equipped and relationally positioned to speak into it.

This is the elder's teaching ministry. It is personal. It is responsive. It is ongoing.

Teaching in Small Groups

Elders who lead or actively participate in small groups have a unique platform for theological formation. The small group context is one of the most effective learning environments available — it is intimate enough for genuine questions, consistent enough for sustained formation, and relational enough for truth to be received as care rather than merely as information.

An elder who leads a small group with theological intentionality is doing some of the most significant teaching ministry in the congregation — even if no one other than the twelve people in the room ever knows it.

Teaching Through Mentoring

One of the most ancient and most effective forms of theological education is the intentional one-on-one relationship between a more mature believer and a less

An elder who is deliberately investing in two or three younger men — meeting with them regularly, walking through Scripture together, answering their questions, sharing his own story of faith and failure — is extending the theological reach of the elder team into the next generation of leadership.

This is not glamorous work. It produces no visible institutional results. But it is exactly the kind of work that 2 Timothy 2:2 describes: “What you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses entrust to faithful men, who will be able to teach others also.” The chain of theological instruction runs through personal relationships, not through institutional structures.

GUARDING THE DOCTRINAL CULTURE

THE TEACHING RESPONSIBILITY OF elders extends beyond individual instruction to the cultivation of the congregation’s overall doctrinal culture. Every congregation has a theological culture — a set of assumptions, emphases, and sensitivities that shape how members read Scripture, what questions they ask, and what they will and won’t accept from the pulpit.

That culture is not neutral. It is formed — either intentionally by the elders, or accidentally by whoever happens to be loudest. Where the elders are not actively cultivating a healthy doctrinal culture, other forces will fill the vacuum: social media influencers, popular books, online preachers, and the various theological winds that blow through evangelical culture in every generation.

This kind of proactive doctrinal stewardship is one of the most important things an elder team does. And it is almost entirely invisible until it is needed.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

If your current elders were evaluated on the “able to teach” qualification — not just as formal teachers but as men who can give instruction and rebuke false teaching — how would they fare?

What theological threats are your congregation members encountering outside the church right now? Is the elder team aware of them and equipped to address them?

Which of your elders are personally investing in the theological development of younger men in the congregation? What would it take to make this a normal expectation for every elder?

What is the current doctrinal culture of your congregation? Was it intentionally cultivated or accidentally formed?

CHAPTER FOUR

The Elder as Overseer

HOW TO LEAD A church without controlling it

The third word the New Testament uses for elders is *episkopos* — overseer. It is the word from which we get the English term “bish—op,” and in many ecclesiastical traditions it has come to refer to a specific hierarchical office. But in the New Testament, it is used interchangeably with “elder” to describe the same set of responsibilities.

The overseer is the elder in his supervisory and organizational function. If the shepherd metaphor emphasizes the personal and relational dimension of elder ministry, the overseer metaphor emphasizes the structural and protective dimension. The overseer watches over. He ensures that things are rightly ordered. He provides direction and accountability.

The organizational and administrative aspects of church life are real and require genuine oversight. Buildings need to be maintained. Finances need to be managed. Staff need to be supervised. Programs need to be evaluated. These are not unspiritual concerns. They are the practical infrastructure

But there is a version of oversight that crosses a line from biblical eldership into something altogether different. And learning to distinguish between the two is one of the most practically important skills a pastor can develop.

OVERSIGHT AS SERVICE, NOT CONTROL

THE KEY PHRASE IN 1 Peter 5:3 is “not domineering over those in your charge, but being examples to the flock.” The word translated “domineering” (*katakyrieuontes*) is the same word used in Matthew 20:25, where Jesus contrasts the leadership style of the Gentiles — who “lord it over” one another — with the servant leadership he calls his disciples to.

The contrast is not between authority and no authority. Elders have genuine authority. Hebrews 13:17 is explicit about this, and the congregation is called to submit to it. The contrast is between authority exercised as domination and authority exercised as service.

The domineering elder uses his position to control outcomes according to his preferences. The servant-overseer uses his position to create the conditions under which the congregation can flourish and the pastor can lead. These are not the same thing, even though both may be using the same institutional authority to do them.

What Legitimate Oversight Looks Like

So what does legitimate, biblically ordered oversight look like? It is helpful to think about it in terms of what the elder team should be doing and what it should not be doing.

The elder team should be providing the pastor with a genuine circle of accountability and support. This means

The elder team should be setting the doctrinal and missional direction of the church in partnership with the pastor. This is not a top-down imposition of their preferences — it is a collaborative discernment process in which the elders bring their knowledge of the congregation and the community, the pastor brings his theological and pastoral leadership, and together they pursue the direction God is calling the church toward.

The elder team should be providing accountability for financial stewardship — not micromanaging every budget line, but ensuring that the church's resources are being used faithfully and that appropriate financial controls are in place.

And the elder team should be making major decisions about significant personnel, property, and financial matters that exceed the authority the congregation has delegated to the pastoral staff.

What Oversight Should Not Look Like

The elder team should not be approving every ministry decision the pastor makes. If the pastor must get board approval to launch a new small group, to schedule a special service, to bring in a guest speaker, or to hire a part-time administrative assistant, the board has moved from oversight to management, and the pastor's ability to lead has been effectively neutralized.

The elder team should not be a court of appeals for every congregational complaint. When a member who is unhappy with a pastoral decision brings it to the board rather than

And the elder team should not be a forum for the personal preferences and agendas of its members. The elder who regularly uses his board position to advance his vision of what the worship should sound like, or what time the service should start, or which staff member he thinks should be hired or fired, has confused his personal preferences with his pastoral calling.

THE ELDER TEAM AND THE SENIOR PASTOR: A PARTNERSHIP MODEL

ONE OF THE MOST important clarifications in recovering a biblical eldership is the clarification of the relationship between the elder team and the senior pastor. In many churches, this relationship is adversarial by design — the board is understood to be a check on the pastor, and the pastor is understood to be a hire of the board. This arrangement produces exactly the kind of governance-over-shepherding culture we have been diagnosing.

A healthier and more biblical model understands the senior pastor and the elder team as partners in the same shepherding mission. The senior pastor is a member of the elder team — typically the leader of it — and his authority to preach, teach, direct staff, and make ministry decisions is understood to flow from his office as elder, not from a contract negotiated with a board.

The other elders provide the senior pastor with

This model requires a level of trust and mutual commitment that institutional governance cannot generate. It has to be built relationally, over time, through the kinds of shared experience and honest conversation that board meetings rarely provide.

OVERSIGHT OF THE CHURCH'S DIRECTION

PERHAPS THE MOST IMPORTANT oversight function of the elder team is the one that gets the least attention in most governance discussions: the oversight of the church's theological and missional direction.

Every church is moving somewhere. The question is whether it is moving intentionally, under clear leadership, with broad congregational awareness of the direction — or whether it is drifting, shaped by whoever is most insistent, most generous, or most recently heard from.

The elder team's oversight of direction is what prevents drift. It requires elders who are engaged enough in the life of the congregation to notice when the culture is shifting. Elders who are theologically grounded enough to evaluate ministry proposals against the church's mission. Elders who are willing to ask hard questions when something feels off, and to have hard conversations when the answers are concerning.

This kind of oversight is not administrative. It is pastoral. And it is irreplaceable.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Draw a line between “oversight” and “micromanagement”

Do you and your elder team function as genuine partners in the same shepherding mission, or more like employer and employee? What would need to change for the former to be true?

What institutional decisions belong to the elder team, and which belong to the pastoral staff? Is this clear in your governance documents and in your team's actual practice?

Is anyone currently providing genuine oversight of your church's theological and missional direction — or is drift happening unchecked?

CHAPTER FIVE

The Elder's Personal Life as Ministry

WHY WHAT YOU DO at home matters as much as what you do in meetings

There is something unusual about the biblical qualifications for eldership. If you were designing a list of requirements for a church governance board, you would probably focus on institutional competencies — financial acumen, decision-making ability, organizational experience, leadership track record. You would want people who are good at running things.

That is not what Paul gave us in 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1.

The qualifications Paul gives are almost entirely about character — about the kind of person an elder is in his ordinary, unobserved daily life. Above reproach. Husband of one wife. Sober-minded. Self-controlled. Respectable. Hospitable. Not a drunkard. Not violent. Not quarrelsome. Not a lover of money. Managing his household well. Having children who are under control.

This is not incidental. It reflects a fundamental conviction that runs through the entire New Testament: in the body of Christ, leadership is never merely positional. It is always personal. The elder does not lead primarily through his vote. He leads primarily through his life.

THE ELDER AS A LIVING ARGUMENT

THE NEW TESTAMENT'S EMPHASIS on elder character makes most sense when you understand the theology underlying it. The elder is not just a leader. He is a visible expression of what the gospel produces in a human life.

Peter makes this explicit. The elder leads not by dominating but by “being examples to the flock.” The Greek word is *typos* — a pattern, a model, a template. The elder's life is something the congregation can look at and say: that is what a Christian looks like. That is what the gospel does to a marriage. That is what a Spirit-filled man looks like under pressure. That is what it means to handle money without being controlled by it.

This is an enormous calling. And it is one that makes no sense at all if the elder's role is primarily institutional.

THE ELDER'S MARRIAGE AND HOUSEHOLD

PAUL DEVOTES MORE ATTENTION to the elder's family than to any other single qualification, which suggests that he considers it especially significant. And it is not hard to see why.

A man who leads his home well — who loves his wife sacrificially, who raises his children with both warmth and discipline, who creates a household where the gospel is not just talked about but lived out — is demonstrating the kind of character that elder ministry requires. A man whose home is in disorder is telling us something important about who he is when no one official is watching.

This is not about perfection. Every family has struggles, and there is no qualification that says the elder's household must be problem-free. The qualification is that he “manages his household well” — that he is engaged, responsible, and present in his family's life in a way that is genuinely loving and broadly effective.

The Question of Children

Paul's reference to elders' children in 1 Timothy 3:4 has generated considerable discussion, especially in an age when pastors' and elders' adult children sometimes walk away from the faith. Is a man disqualified from eldership if his adult child is not a believer?

The qualification as written refers to children “in submission” and “not open to the charge of debauchery or insubordination.” The context suggests children who are still in the home and under the elder's direct care. The question is whether the man is functioning as a responsible, engaged father with his children, not whether his adult children have

That said, the spiritual trajectory of an elder's children is not irrelevant. If the children of an elder are known in the congregation primarily for their rebellion, their contempt for faith, or their public disregard for the values their father teaches — this creates a real and legitimate question about the credibility of his witness and the integrity of his household. This is not a formula. It requires pastoral wisdom and case-by-case discernment. But it cannot be ignored.

THE ELDER'S INNER LIFE

THE PERSONAL QUALIFICATIONS PAUL lists in 1 Timothy 3 include several that relate specifically to the elder's interior life — his emotional health, his relationship to his own appetites, his self-governance.

Sober-minded. Self-controlled. Not a drunkard. Not greedy for dishonest gain. Not quick-tempered.

These qualifications matter for the same reason the household qualifications matter: they reveal the man underneath the title. An elder who struggles with anger but has learned to manage it in public settings is not genuinely self-controlled. He is performing self-control in professional contexts while actually being ruled by his temper. And eventually, in moments of stress or conflict, the real man will emerge.

The elder whose spiritual disciplines are genuine — who actually prays, actually reads Scripture for his own formation rather than just for preparation, actually practices the sabbath rest he preaches, actually lives in honest community with other men who can challenge and correct him — is building the kind of inner life that sustains elder ministry

The elder who is performing spiritual health without possessing it is, in the words of the qualification, not “above reproach” in the sense Paul intends — because the reproach is simply hidden.

THE ELDER’S REPUTATION OUTSIDE THE CHURCH

ONE OF THE MOST overlooked qualifications in 1 Timothy 3 is verse 7: “Moreover, he must be well thought of by outsiders.”

This qualification is not about being popular. It is about integrity. The elder who is respected in the congregation but known in the community for sharp business practices, for how he treats service workers, for the inconsistency between his Sunday morning persona and his Monday afternoon behavior — this man is not qualified for the office, regardless of his standing in the church.

The reason Paul gives is significant: so that he may not fall into disgrace, into a snare of the devil. The elder whose outside reputation is compromised is a vulnerability for the entire congregation. When his behavior outside the church becomes public knowledge inside the church, the damage extends far beyond his personal reputation.

This qualification also has a positive dimension. The elder who is genuinely respected in the community — whose neighbors trust him, whose colleagues rely on him, whose business dealings are consistently above reproach — is a living testimony to the transforming power of the gospel. His integrity in the world makes the church’s message credible in the world.

How is the personal life of your current elders being assessed, not just their institutional performance? Is anyone paying attention to how they are doing at home?

Are your elders' lives genuinely exemplary enough to serve as models for the congregation? What would it look like to take the "being examples" qualification seriously in your elder selection process?

What do the neighbors, colleagues, and business associates of your elders think of them? Does that reputation serve or undermine the church's witness?

What accountability structures exist to help your elders sustain the personal disciplines that the office requires? Is anyone helping them stay spiritually healthy?

CHAPTER SIX

Building an Elder Team That Functions Biblically

FROM GOVERNANCE BOARD TO genuine shepherd-team

Let's assume you are convinced. The vision is clear. Elders should be shepherds, teachers, overseers, and examples. The current reality — in your church or in most churches — falls significantly short of that vision. The question is: what do you do about it?

This is where most books on eldership leave pastors. They have articulated the biblical vision with clarity and conviction, and then they have trusted the reader to figure out how to get there. This chapter is an attempt to do better than that.

What follows is not a formula. Every church is different, and the specific path from where your elder team is to where it should be will depend on your history, your relationships, your polity, and God's timing. But there are principles that

START WITH EDUCATION, NOT RESTRUCTURING

THE MOST COMMON MISTAKE pastors make when they recognize an elder team dysfunction is to reach for structural solutions immediately. They want to revise the bylaws, rewrite the elder role descriptions, change the meeting agenda, and reorganize the authority structure. All of those things may eventually be necessary. But none of them should come first.

What must come first is education. Before you can change what your elders do, you need to change what they understand about what they are supposed to do. And that requires sustained, patient, relational investment in helping them see the biblical vision.

This is shepherding work in itself. You are not managing an institutional change process. You are discipling a group of men toward a new understanding of their calling. And it requires the same things good discipleship always requires: regular conversation, shared reading and study, prayer together, and the kind of honest relationship in which real questions can be asked and real answers can be given.

Consider a multi-month commitment to walking your elder team through the key New Testament texts on eldership. Read this book together. Read other resources together. Invite honest conversation about what you are finding and how it applies to your specific context. You may be surprised by what happens when men who genuinely love the church encounter a biblical vision of what they are being

BUILD THE RELATIONAL CULTURE OF THE TEAM

AN ELDER TEAM THAT functions as genuine partners in the same shepherding mission requires a relational culture that most governance boards never develop. The men on the team need to actually know each other. They need to pray together in ways that are specific and personal, not merely ceremonial. They need to have honest conversations outside of formal meetings. They need to develop the kind of trust that allows real disagreement to happen without damaging the relationship.

This does not happen by accident, and it does not happen primarily in meetings. It happens in the kinds of contexts where men are simply together — at a meal, on a retreat, in a shared ministry experience, in the kind of unhurried conversation that does not have an agenda or a decision to make.

The annual elder retreat — even a simple overnight away from the church — is one of the most valuable investments you can make in building the relational culture of the team. Bring a book to discuss. Pray together with genuine depth. Share stories. Name struggles. Do the things that move a group of men from institutional colleagues to genuine brothers in a shared calling.

The quality of your elder team's relational culture will determine the quality of their pastoral care more than any structural arrangement you can build.

ONCE THE RELATIONAL AND educational foundation is being built, it becomes possible to have clear, productive conversations about what each person on the elder team is responsible for. This is where the work of role clarification happens — not in a legalistic or contractual way, but in a way that creates genuine shared ownership and eliminates the ambiguity that governance dysfunction thrives in.

A simple framework: the elder team collectively owns the church's theological direction, the care of the pastoral staff, the accountability for major financial and institutional decisions, and the overall spiritual health of the congregation. Individual elders may be assigned specific areas of care — a particular group of families, a specific ministry area, a set of pastoral care responsibilities. And the senior pastor leads the team in the exercise of all of these responsibilities while also carrying his specific callings as the primary preacher and theological leader.

What the elder team does not own — and this is critical — is the day-to-day management of the pastoral staff's ministry. Elders do not approve sermon topics. They do not supervise staff directly. They do not make decisions that the congregation has delegated to the pastoral leadership. The boundary between oversight and micromanagement must be actively maintained, and it requires ongoing conversation to do so.

THE MEETING AGENDA AS A CULTURE SIGNAL

practical ways to move an elder team from governance to shepherding is to change what you talk about when you meet. The meeting agenda is a culture signal. What the team spends its time discussing is what the team believes matters.

An elder team that wants to function as shepherds should spend the majority of its formal meeting time on pastoral matters: the spiritual health of specific members who need care, the theological questions the congregation is wrestling with, the prayer for the flock that is the elder's fundamental calling. Institutional business — budgets, facilities, policy questions — should occupy the minority of the agenda and should be handled efficiently and without drama.

This is a simple change that communicates enormous things about what the team values. When a new elder attends his first meeting and spends ninety percent of the time praying for members by name and discussing the pastoral needs of the congregation, he has received a powerful formation experience in what it means to be a biblical elder. That formation will shape how he understands the role for the rest of his tenure.

MOVING FROM A BOARD TO A TEAM: A TIMELINE

REAL INSTITUTIONAL CHANGE TAKES time. If you are working with an existing elder team that has functioned as a governance board for years or decades, you are not going to transform the culture in a quarter. You are looking at a multi-year investment.

In the first year, focus almost entirely on education and relationship. Do not propose structural changes. Build trust.

In the second year, begin introducing role clarity conversations. What is the elder team responsible for? What are individual elders responsible for? Where are the boundaries of pastoral staff authority? These conversations will surface tensions and questions that need to be worked through — and working through them together is itself a formation process.

In the third year and beyond, the structural changes that were impossible in year one become possible because the relational and cultural foundation has been built. New elders can be identified and developed with the biblical vision from the start. Existing governance documents can be revised to reflect a more biblical polity. The meeting culture is established.

This is slow work. But it is the right kind of slow — the kind that produces lasting change rather than institutional rearrangement that gets reversed the next time the leadership changes.

WHEN PROGRESS STALLS: THE HARD CONVERSATION

THERE ARE ELDERS WHO will not make this transition. Men who have been institutional leaders for so long that the pastoral calling does not register as theirs. Men who are invested in the governance model because it gives them a form of power they would lose in a genuine shepherding model. Men who simply lack the character or spiritual formation to function as biblical elders, even

If your elder team has men like this — and most established churches do — the question eventually becomes whether the entire team’s culture can be transformed while they remain on it.

The honest answer is: sometimes yes, often no.

This is where the courage of pastoral leadership meets the gentleness of pastoral care. The conversation with an elder who is an obstacle to the team’s development must be honest, loving, specific, and clear. It must name the gap between what the role requires and what the man is providing. And it must offer a genuine path forward — either a season of intentional growth toward the standard, or a gracious and honored transition off the team.

These conversations are among the hardest a pastor will have. And they are among the most important. Because the elder team that cannot have them will remain a governance board indefinitely. And the sheep will continue to go without shepherds.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What is the first practical step you could take toward beginning the educational and relational work of rebuilding your elder team’s culture?

What would your next elder meeting agenda look like if you applied the principle that pastoral matters should dominate institutional ones?

Are there any men currently on your elder team who are obstacles to the team’s development toward a biblical model? What has prevented the necessary conversation from happening?

What is your three-year vision for your elder team? What

**BUILDING AN ELDER TEAM THAT FUNCTIONS
BIBLICALLY**

Conclusion: A Reset

TOWARD ELDERS WHO ACTUALLY Shepherd

We have covered a lot of ground. We have diagnosed the problem — elder boards that govern instead of shepherd — and traced its roots in cultural accommodation rather than biblical reflection. We have examined the three primary New Testament images of the elder: shepherd, teacher, and overseer. We have insisted on the personal life of the elder as a non-negotiable dimension of the office. And we have outlined a practical path for building an elder team that functions according to this vision.

The question now is what you do next.

If you are a pastor who has been carrying a congregation alone while a governance board passes resolutions, I want you to know that you are not imagining the problem and you are not exaggerating its cost. The vision this book has been advocating is the biblical norm, not an idealistic aspiration. And the work of moving your church toward it is worth the difficulty it will require.

If you are an elder who has been functioning primarily as

If you are a lay leader of any kind who is reading this because you want to understand what healthy church leadership looks like, I hope you leave with a clear enough picture that you can recognize it — and pursue it — in your own context.

—[The Reset Framework]—

Here is a simple framework for beginning the work of realigning your elder team around the biblical vision. It is not comprehensive. But it is a starting point.

First: read the key texts together. Acts 20:17–38. 1 Peter 5:1–4. 1 Timothy 3:1–7. Titus 1:5–9. Hebrews 13:17. Read them in a single sitting. Without commentary. Without agenda. Just the texts. Then ask: what do these passages say our role is? Let the conversation go wherever it goes.

Second: audit the current reality. Take your last six months of elder meeting agendas. What percentage of the time was devoted to institutional governance versus pastoral care? How many members did the elder team personally contact for care in that period? How many hospital visits? How many one-on-ones? Be honest. The gap between what you find and what Scripture describes is the distance you need to travel.

Third: identify one change you will make immediately. Not

Fourth: assign pastoral care responsibilities. Every elder should know which members of the congregation he is specifically responsible for. Not managing — caring for. Praying for. Reaching out to. Visiting when they are sick. Noticing when they are absent. This is the basic unit of biblical shepherding, and it can begin tomorrow.

Fifth: plan an annual elder retreat. Get away. Pray together. Study Scripture together. Share honestly about how the team is doing. Build the relational culture that institutional meetings cannot produce.

None of this is complicated. All of it is demanding. The demanding part is not the knowledge — it is the will. The will to lead differently. The will to hold the office to the standard Scripture sets for it. The will to tell the truth about the gap between what is and what should be, and to do something about it.

Now may the God of peace who brought again from the dead our Lord Jesus, the great shepherd of the sheep, by the blood of the eternal covenant, equip you with everything good that you may do his will, working in us that which is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ, to whom be glory forever and ever. Amen. — Hebrews 13:20–21

The great Shepherd has called men to be under-shepherds in his church. That calling is not diminished by the ways it has been culturally distorted. It is available to be recovered,

The sheep are waiting. Go shepherd them.

Appendix

A SAMPLE ELDER ROLE Description

The following is a sample role description for elders. It is designed to reflect the biblical picture of shepherding eldership articulated in this book. Adapt it to your specific context, polity, and congregational culture.

Position: Elder

Reports to: The elder team collectively, under the lordship of Jesus Christ

Term: Typically two to three years, renewable

PRIMARY RESPONSIBILITIES

Shepherd a specific group of congregation members through prayer, personal contact, pastoral visits, and spiritual care.

Teach and model sound doctrine in personal relationships, small group settings, and wherever opportunities arise.

Guard the doctrinal health of the congregation by identifying theological drift and addressing it appropriately.

Provide accountability and support to the senior pastor

Participate meaningfully in elder team meetings with preparation, presence, and pastoral engagement.

Provide oversight of major institutional decisions — financial, personnel, and directional — in partnership with the pastoral staff.

Model the Christian life in marriage, family, vocation, and community in a way that is genuinely exemplary.

Develop the next generation of leaders through intentional mentoring and discipling relationships.

QUALIFICATIONS

The elder must meet the qualifications described in 1 Timothy 3:1–7 and Titus 1:5–9. These qualifications are assessed by the existing elder team through a formal evaluation process that includes self-assessment, spouse conversation, congregational input, and elder team discernment.

A Sample Elder Team Covenant

We, the elders of [Church Name], covenant together before God and the congregation to fulfill the office of elder according to the biblical standard and in the following specific ways:

We will pray for every member of the congregation regularly, and for specific members assigned to our individual care.

We will hold firm to the trustworthy word as taught, and will faithfully instruct in sound doctrine and rebuke those who contradict it.

We will shepherd — not merely govern — the flock

We will support and pray for our senior pastor, providing honest accountability and genuine partnership in the shared shepherding mission.

We will model the Christian life in our households, our vocations, and our community in ways that are worthy of imitation.

We will resolve conflicts with one another directly and quickly, refusing to allow unaddressed disagreements to damage the team's unity or effectiveness.

We will meet together regularly with spiritual intentionality, devoting the majority of our shared time to pastoral matters rather than institutional ones.

We will submit to honest evaluation of our elder ministry annually, and will seek to grow in our calling throughout our tenure.

Signed: _____

Date: _____

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